

The Cost of True Happiness

In Plato's *Symposium*, Socrates presents Diotima's model of love, a ladder of love in which progressing up the various stages leads the lover to an understanding of virtue and the attainment of happiness. I claim that Austen endorses Diotima's ladder of love as a path towards virtue and true happiness, but she introduces two additions that Diotima does not explicitly address: 1. Selflessness is a key trait needed to progress up the ladder, and 2. Cultivating selflessness requires the potentially painful sacrifice of fleeting, emotional happiness in exchange for true and lasting happiness.

Diotima's model of love contains three central points that I reconstruct below to analyze in relation to *Sense and Sensibility*.

I. "Love is wanting to possess the good forever" (Plato, 52). Diotima begins by addressing the human desire to possess the beautiful, arguing that this is a subset of a general human desire to possess good, which in turn stems from a desire for happiness. Thus, Diotima defines love as the desire to keep the good forever because this will bring the lover happiness described as *eudaimonia* (Plato, 50) that refers to living a good life of complete fulfillment and well-being. Here, "goodness" is used in the Platonic sense of being as close to the standard of perfection in Form as possible. Objects that are beautiful are closer to their perfect Form and therefore are closer to goodness. In this way, beauty is a manifestation of goodness, so that which is beautiful is good, and pursuit of goodness is the generalized motive for love.

II. There is a ladder of love that will lead the lover to see the true Form of Beauty. The ladder begins in the physical realm and progresses up towards metaphysical concepts, terminating at the Form of Beauty. As a lover masters each form of love, their perception of beauty and mode of loving becomes more pure and untarnished by attachment to the imperfect instances humans perceive in the physical realm. Diotima's ladder of love starts at the love of one body, a physically-grounded form of love. Once a person is able to see the beauty of one body, they will realize that all bodies have beauty, and thus progress to a love of all bodies. Then, the lover moves beyond the physical and sees the beauty in people's souls, after which the lover's conception of love expands beyond people to the beauty of thought, in customs and laws. From here, they progress to a love of knowledge. Once a lover has understood beauty in all these forms, they arrive at the end of the ladder and know the pure Form of Beauty itself. Diotima clarifies what is meant by progression up the ladder by stating that once a lover sees beauty at a higher level, such as beauty in activities and laws, "he will think that the beauty of bodies is a thing of no importance" (Plato, 58). This is not to say that the lover should entirely abandon loving bodies, but rather that they now have a more holistic understanding of love, so the love of bodies no longer encapsulates the lover's full capacity to love in a higher form.

III. Once a person has reached the end of the ladder and looks upon true Beauty, he will give birth "to true virtue (because he is in touch with true Beauty)" (Plato, 60). Diotima's conclusion is that

love is a means by which people may learn to see purer forms of beauty; from the true form of Beauty, the lover can learn to cultivate true virtue that aligns with the true Forms they see. Thus, progressing up the ladder of love is a progression towards virtue, and at the end of this journey, the lover will know how to be virtuous. The virtuous lover possesses true goodness and therefore lives in a pure state of well-being and happiness.

I claim that *Sense & Sensibility* endorses Diotima's ladder of love as a model for attaining virtue, in which higher forms of love are closer to virtuousness; however, it also clarifies that while the path towards virtue is not always emotionally "happy," it leads to a more fulfilling life that is a higher form of happiness. Through Marianne's transformation and Lucy's lack thereof, Austen suggests that learning self-sacrifice and resisting ephemeral happiness is necessary for virtue development, illustrating the tension between emotional happiness and *eudaimonia*.

By examining Marianne's early emotion-governed behavior, we see Austen's portrayal of selfish love aligns with the lower rungs of Diotima's ladder. At the start of the novel, Marianne's extreme sensibility leads to narcissistic behavior, unable to accept differing opinions and often offending others. Marianne's treatment of the Steele sisters is described as "invariable coldness" because she could not tolerate "any thing like impertinence, vulgarity, inferiority of parts, or even difference of taste from herself" (Austen, 93). Marianne's rude behavior transparently reflects her emotional dislike, insensitive to the feelings of the Steele sisters or social manners, which points towards a selfishness that serves the love of one body: herself. In particular, the inclusion of differing tastes indicates just how pervasive Marianne's narcissism is, that even lighter topics like aesthetics can warrant Marianne's immediate disapproval and rejection. It is worth noting that the virtuousness of Marianne's actions themselves is not what is being judged in relation to the ladder of love here – a person who understands the love of souls may still choose to disengage from the Steele sisters due to their lack of virtue. The problem with Marianne's behavior arises from the lack of discernment that forms the basis of this decision – she operates in a self-gratifying manner, not from a contemplation of the beauty of souls or customs; thus, it is selfish internal motive that illuminates her low status on Diotima's ladder of love early in the novel. This becomes most evident in Marianne's romance with Willoughby. Ignoring the counsel of Elinor, Marianne acts in self-interest to pursue the beauty she sees in Willoughby because he appears so similar to herself. Her short-sighted love leads to happiness in the moment but eventually to a near-fatal illness that seems to be Austen's indication that love of one body, particularly a selfish love, does not lead to virtue. Connecting Austen's discussion of selfishness to Diotima's model, the "goodness" Marianne saw in Willoughby is distorted by her subjectivity; only seeing beauty from her own perspective hinders her from seeing Willoughby for the scoundrel he really is and clouds her discernment of true beauty. Thus, Austen's description of selfishness is deeply intertwined with Diotima's lower forms of love. From this, we conclude that in *Sense & Sensibility*, selfishly motivated love can be categorized under

love of body, the lowest rung of Diotima's ladder, demonstrating an alignment between Austen's perception of virtue and Diotima's ladder of love.

In contrast to Marianne and Willoughby's relationship, Austen introduces the concept of self-sacrifice in Marianne's relationship with Colonel Brandon, which ultimately brings a more lasting happiness. In relation to Colonel Brandon, "she found herself at nineteen, submitting to new attachments, entering on new duties, placed in a new home, a wife, the mistress of a family, and the patroness of a village... Marianne found her own happiness in forming his, ... and her whole heart became, in time, as much devoted to her husband as it had once been to Willoughby" (Austen, 279). Colonel Brandon, who she had initially deemed too old and melancholic, becomes the object of her lasting love. Specifically, Austen claims she finds happiness in the selfless act of bringing him happiness. Marianne surpasses the love of body that she had for herself and her disdain for Colonel Brandon's physical appearance to see the value of his soul, showing a progression up Diotima's ladder of love. However, the first sentence uses a reflexive construction that carries a passive tone; this frames her marriage as an event that came upon her, rather than one she pursued. While there is selflessness in the way Marianne finds happiness in restoring Colonel Brandon's, this comes at the cost of sacrificing part of her headstrong nature that drove her early pursuits of emotional happiness. Nevertheless, Marianne ultimately enjoys a stable happy ending, suggesting that Austen approves of this self-sacrifice as a necessary and worthy loss to attain virtue. Thus, Marianne's character arc indicates how Austen aligns selflessness with Diotima's higher forms of love; however, she proposes the necessity of sacrificing parts of oneself and tempering one's desires in order to ascend the ladder of love, which is painful in the moment but ultimately contributes to lasting happiness.

On the surface, the unvirtuous Lucy Steele also appears to attain happiness by receiving the wealth she pursues, but her selfishness bars her from understanding virtue and thus limits her to a weak form of happiness. Lucy Steele is a calculating character who, unlike Marianne, does not progress throughout the novel. Initially attached to Edward for four years before rapidly pivoting to marry his brother Robert for his inheritance, Lucy clearly does not operate out of love for either. Instead, she operates out of a love of wealth. According to Diotima, her pursuits are misguided love; materialism is a pursuit of immediate gratification, not a pursuit of true goodness. But, at the end of the novel, "setting aside the jealousies and ill-will continually subsisting between Fanny and Lucy, in which their husbands of course took a part, as well as the frequent domestic disagreements between Robert and Lucy themselves, nothing could exceed the harmony in which they all lived together" (Austen, 278). Austen's sarcastic tone indicates Lucy's ending is by no means perfectly happy; however, she still has a reasonably satisfactory fate. Austen does not contradict Diotima that virtue leads to happiness, since we showed in the previous paragraph that characters who pursue virtue do find happiness, but she adds a caveat— she argues that happiness in the worldly sense is not limited to the virtuous. Even if the object of love is not good, attaining that object will still bring subjective happiness and gratification to the

possessor. However, this kind of happiness is less stable than the happiness that stems from virtue. In Lucy's case, discord mars her domestic happiness, a consequence of her inability to exercise self-denial and control her selfish desire for wealth. Thus, while Austen's portrayal of *eudaimonia* manifests in the stability and longevity of happiness of her virtuous characters' fates, she also argues that unvirtuous behavior is not necessarily punished by emotional unhappiness, but will leave the unvirtuous character lacking in a truer state of contentment.

Reading *Sense & Sensibility* through the lens of Diotima is beneficial for providing a framework to understand Austen's portrayal of virtue, because Austen's ranking of virtuous behavior closely aligns with Diotima's. Diotima's ladder of love explains the motivation behind character behavior and classifies such motives at various levels of virtuousness, which helps the reader distill Austen's perspective on virtue from the drama and witticism. However, Austen presents another trait that is deeply intertwined with her characters' virtuousness, which Diotima does not explicitly mention: selflessness. Austen suggests that progression towards virtue requires self-sacrifice, particularly in exercising self-control to resist the appeal of immediate gratification. Thus, it is in fact also beneficial to read Diotima through the lens of Austen; using the perspective that Austen presents on selflessness being a crucial part of ascending the ladder of love, we are encouraged to question to what extent achieving Diotima's true happiness comes at the expense of temporal, emotional happiness. Reading purely through Diotima's lens may hinder our ability to reconcile the abstract concept of *eudaimonia* with an imperfect human understanding of happiness and the 18th century portrayal of happiness; however, by placing Austen and Diotima in dialogue with each other, Diotima brings more clarity to the picture of virtue that Austen presents, while Austen provides a tangible method of climbing Diotima's ladder through selflessness and helps readers understand the potentially painful but worthwhile tradeoffs that must be made in order to attain true virtue and happiness.

Works Cited

- Austen, Jane. *Sense and Sensibility*. 3rd ed., edited by John Mullan, Oxford University Press, 2019.
- Plato. *The Symposium*. Translated by Alexander Nehamas and Paul Woodruff, edited by Paul Woodruff, Hackett Publishing, 1989.